



# Academic English Reading



# Agenda

- Reading skill: recognizing literal vs figurative meaning
- Vocabulary: complement or compliment?
- Reading text: City under Siege



## VANISHING CITIES

If all the ice on Earth melts, scientists estimate that the seas could rise up by more than 60 meters (200 feet), covering much of the Statue of Liberty.

### Warm Up

Discuss these questions with a partner.

1. Which are the most crowded cities or regions in your country? Why are they crowded?
2. What places in the world do you think are most at risk from a rise in sea levels?
3. Can you think of any places that have recently experienced floods? What was the result?





## Before You Read

**A. Quiz.** How much do you know about Venice? Answer the questions. Then check your answers at the bottom of the page.

1. Approximately how many people visit Venice each year?

- a. 200,000                      b. 2,000,000                       c. 20,000,000

2. Venice is regularly threatened by *acqua alta* (high tides) and has been sinking into the water for years. Over the last century, how much has the city sunk?

- a. 13 cm (5 inches)                      b. 25 cm (10 inches)  c. 38 cm (15 inches)

3. What did Venice recently prohibit people from doing in the Piazza San Marco (the city's main square)?

-  a. feeding birds                      b. selling T-shirts                      c. riding skateboards

**B. Skimming.** Look quickly at the passage on pages 75–79. Which problem facing Venice do you think the article is mainly about? Circle one option below. Then read through the passage to check your ideas.

- a. dangers caused by rising tides                       b. problems caused by tourism  
c. the city's declining birthrate                      d. rising levels of pollution

 Every year, crowds of tourists travel to Venice, Italy. Highlights for many visitors are the chance to ride in a gondola along the famous Grand Canal (**above**) and to attend Carnevale, an elaborate costume party that is one of the city's biggest celebrations (**above right**).



4A

# CITY UNDER SIEGE



# VOCABULARY

*Carousal*  
*hacchanian*  
*debauchery*  
*depraved*  
*disputed*  
*ity*

*denounce*  
*deride/derisive*  
*diatribe*  
*disparage*  
*excoriate*  
*gainsay*  
*harangue*  
*impugn*  
*inveigh*  
*lambaste*  
*objurgate*  
*obloquy*  
*opprobrium*  
*pillory*

**DIFFICULT TO UNDERSTAND**

authoritarian  
despotic  
dogmatic  
hegemonic (hegemony)  
imperious  
peremptory  
tyrannical

**DIFFICULT TO UNDERSTAND**

abstruse  
ambiguous  
arcane  
bemusing  
cryptic  
enigmatic

**ECCENTRIC/DISSIMILAR**

aberrant  
anachronism  
anomalous  
discrete  
eclectic  
esoteric  
iconoclast

**EMBARRASS**

abash  
chagrin  
compunct  
contrition  
diffidence  
expiate  
foible  
gauche

A **lagoon** is a body of water cut off from the open sea by coral reefs or sand bars.



The **stratosphere** is the atmospheric layer between about 15 and 50 km (10 and 30 miles) above the Earth.



Something that is left in someone's **wake** remains behind after the person has left

Something that is **municipal** is controlled or owned by the government of a city or town



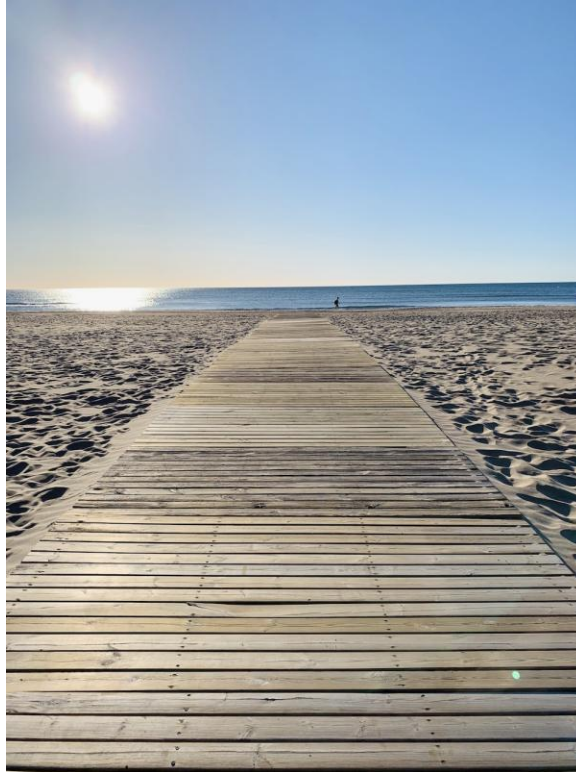
**MUNICIPAL**



**Aesthetics** is a branch of philosophy dealing with the nature of beauty



A **boardwalk** is a footpath made of wooden boards



Somewhere that is **blissfully** empty is a place that is happy and peaceful because it is



© CanStockPhoto.com

**Inflict:** impose something unwelcome on; cause

**Impose:** force

Something that is **inexorable** cannot be prevented from continuing or progressing



**Lodging** is temporary, often rented, accommodation



**Passerelle** is elevated boardwalks that allow visitors to appreciate Venice's beauty without getting their feet wet.



**Aboriginals** are the original and native people of a country or region





### Usage

**Complement** and **compliment** sound alike but have different meanings.

**Complement** means "things may be different, but they combine well together," e.g., (v.) *The tie **complemented** his suit.* (n.) *The tie is a good **complement** to his suit.*

**Compliment** means "to say something nice to or about someone," e.g., (v.) *My daughter **complimented** me on my new dress.* (n.) *My daughter gave me a nice **compliment** about my new dress.*



**ATTENTION  
TO DETAILS**



## Vocabulary Practice

- A. Completion.** Complete the information by circling the correct word in each pair.

A popular image of the European Alps consists of cowbells, cheese-making, and quiet villages **1. (framed / imposed)** against a background of snow-capped mountains. But a less **2. (sentimental / complementary)** picture must also include the 12 million trucks and about 50 million cars that cross the mountains each year.

The movement of 77 million tons of goods annually through the mountains **3. (frames / inflicts)** significant environmental damage on the Alpine environment. Carbon dioxide (CO<sub>2</sub>) from vehicle fumes becomes trapped in the narrow valleys beneath an upper layer of warmer air. The steep valley walls also **4. (maximize / implement)** the sounds generated by the traffic. The **5. (inadequate / elevated)** levels of noise and pollution **6. (impose / complement)** serious problems on the health of Alpine residents.

Laws have been **7. (elevated / implemented)** to reduce the number of vehicles in residential areas, but they have so far proved largely **8. (inadequate / maximized)** for reducing the overall volume of traffic. There are hopeful signs, however: October 2010 saw the completion of the first of two single-track tunnels comprising the Gotthard Base Tunnel—the **9. (sentimental / so-called)** GBT—which at 57 kilometers (35 miles) is the world's longest rail tunnel. It is hoped that the rail tunnel will help reduce the environmental strain on one of the world's most famous landscapes.



▶ The purpose of the Gotthard Base Tunnel is to reduce traffic on roads and shift the focus to rail transport.

### Vocabulary Practice

- A. 1. framed; 2. sentimental; 3. inflicts;  
4. maximize; 5. elevated; 6. impose;  
7. implemented; 8. inadequate; 9. so-called  
B. 1. inflict; 2. maximize; 3. inadequate;  
4. framed; 5. sentimental; 6. complement;  
7. elevated; 8. implement; 9. so-called; 10. impose

framed  
imposed  
sentimental  
complementary  
so-called  
frames  
inflict  
maximize  
implement  
inadequate  
elevated  
impose  
complement  
elevated  
implemented

1. \_\_\_\_\_: cause something undesirable
2. \_\_\_\_\_: to increase as much as possible
3. \_\_\_\_\_: not enough
4. \_\_\_\_\_: surrounded or outlined
5. \_\_\_\_\_: nostalgic for things in the past
6. \_\_\_\_\_: differ, but go well together
7. \_\_\_\_\_: raised up higher
8. \_\_\_\_\_: carry out, fulfill
9. \_\_\_\_\_: generally named or known as
10. \_\_\_\_\_: force something on someone

B. 1. inflict; 2. maximize; 3. inadequate;  
4. framed; 5. sentimental; 6. complement;  
7. elevated; 8. implement; 9. so-called; 10. impose

framed  
imposed  
sentimental  
complementary  
so-called  
frame  
inflict  
maximize  
implement  
inadequate  
elevated  
impose  
complement  
elevated  
implement

1. inflict \_\_\_\_\_: cause something undesirable
2. maximize \_\_\_\_\_: to increase as much as possible
3. inadequate \_\_\_\_\_: not enough
4. framed \_\_\_\_\_: surrounded or outlined
5. sentimental \_\_\_\_\_: nostalgic for things in the past
6. complement \_\_\_\_\_: differ, but go well together
7. elevated \_\_\_\_\_: raised up higher
8. implement \_\_\_\_\_: carry out, fulfill
9. so-called \_\_\_\_\_: generally named or known as
10. impose \_\_\_\_\_: force something on someone



# Quizlet<sup>TM</sup>

<https://quizlet.com/631922068/reading-explorer-5-unit-4-reading-a-flash-cards/>

Take 15 minutes to read  
the text and answer  
questions

## Reading Comprehension

1. c; 2. c; 3. a (lines 16–20); 4. b (line 47); 5. b  
(lines 63–67); 6. a; 7. a

## Reading Comprehension

**Multiple Choice.** Choose the best answer for each question.

### Main Idea

1. What is the main idea of this article?
- a. Besides flooding, Venice faces several other serious environmental problems.
  - b. The flooding problem in Venice is caused mainly by rain, not by the *acqua alta*.
  - c. The most difficult problem facing Venice is the large number of tourists it receives.
  - d. Because tides are rising and foundations are sinking, Venice is disappearing into the sea.

### Rhetorical Purpose

2. Why does the author present the statistics in paragraph D?
- a. to indicate that more tourists are coming to Venice than before
  - b. to emphasize the population decline in Venice
  - c. to contrast the number of tourists with the number of residents
  - d. to point out the dangers of serious flooding

### Inference

3. What can be inferred about the holiday weekend in May 2008, mentioned in the article?
- a. There were more tourists than residents in the city.
  - b. Many residents left the city because of the floods.
  - c. All of the city center's parking lots were full of cars.
  - d. Vendors ran out of snacks for tourists such as pizza and gelato.

### Detail

4. What does Massimo Cacciari say about the young people of Venice in paragraph G?
- a. Most of them have moved to the nearby town of Mogliano.
  - b. They find it is too expensive to live in Venice these days.
  - c. They are involved in cleaning canals, restoring buildings, and raising foundations.
  - d. Many of them live in houses that have been passed down from their parents.

### Detail

5. Which of the following is given as an example of an ordinary resident of Venice?
- a. Massimo Cacciari
  - b. Silvia Zanon
  - c. Thomas Mann
  - d. Augusto Salvadori

### Vocabulary

6. The phrase *off the books* (line 136) indicates that much of the tourist business in Venice is done \_\_\_\_\_.
- a. unofficially
  - b. carelessly
  - c. unwillingly
  - d. rapidly

### Reference

7. The word *they* in line 141 refers to the \_\_\_\_\_.
- a. people who live in Venice
  - b. International Center of Studies on the Tourist Economy
  - c. people who say that Venice's wounds are self-inflicted
  - d. tourists who visit Venice





# Discussion

In groups of 5 students  
discuss the following:

## Critical Thinking

**Evaluating:** Do you think that the author offers enough evidence to support her main idea? Why or why not?

**Analyzing:** "[Tourism] is the heart and soul of the Venetian economy—good and bad" (lines 137–139). What effects (good and bad) does the author mention in the passage? What other positive and negative effects can tourism have on a city or a region?







READING SKILL

Skill

# Literal vs. Figurative Language





# Figurative Language VS. Literal Language

## Figurative Language

- He ran like the wind.

## Literal Language

- He ran fast.



# Examples



| Figurative Language | Literal Meaning                | Figurative Meaning                                       |
|---------------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Simile              | He has big feet.               | <b>His <u>feet</u> are as big as <u>skateboards</u>.</b> |
| Metaphor            | Her hair is very soft.         | <b>Her <u>hair</u> is <u>silky</u>.</b>                  |
| Hyperbole           | The backpack feels very heavy. | <b>The backpack weighs a ton.</b>                        |
| Personification     | Lava erupted from the volcano. | <b>The volcano spit out lava from its mouth.</b>         |





## FIGURATIVE

My backpack weighs a ton.

=



## LITERAL

My backpack is very heavy



Let's take quiz on understanding figurative meaning!

? QUIZ  
TIME

<https://wordwall.net/resource/9427683/english/figurative-language>

## Recognizing Literal vs. Figurative Language

Some words and phrases in the reading passage have a literal meaning, while others have a figurative meaning. When you read, it is important to be able to recognize when figurative language is being used instead of literal language. Literal language means exactly what it says. Figurative language, such as similes, metaphors, and personification, uses words with a meaning that is different from the literal interpretation.

Read these two sentences.

*The farmers plowed their fields.* (literal)

*The ship plowed through the sea.* (figurative)

In the first sentence, farmers use real plows (agricultural tools) to prepare their land for planting. In the second sentence, a metaphor, the ship moves through the sea *like* a plow. There is no real plow.



▲ A plow is a tool used by farmers to loosen or turn the soil. The word *plow* can also be used to describe a ship cutting through the water like a plow.

## READING SKILL PRACTICE

Take 10 mins to  
answer questions

**A. Classification.** Find these words or phrases in the article. Mark them **L** if used literally and **F** if they are used figuratively.

1. flooding (line 8) \_\_\_\_\_
2. stratosphere (line 12) \_\_\_\_\_
3. flood (line 14) \_\_\_\_\_
4. foundations (line 42) \_\_\_\_\_
5. elevated (line 61) \_\_\_\_\_
6. poetic (line 72) \_\_\_\_\_
7. theme park (line 81) \_\_\_\_\_
8. consumed (line 96) \_\_\_\_\_
9. garbage collection (line 100) \_\_\_\_\_
10. pilgrims (line 111) \_\_\_\_\_
11. wounds (line 141) \_\_\_\_\_
12. bruised (line 169) \_\_\_\_\_

### Reading Skill

1. L; 2. F; 3. F; 4. L; 5. L; 6. F; 7. F; 8. F; 9. L;  
10. L; 11. F; 12. F



Any  
Questions